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TOWNS AND HILLFORTS OF CHERNIGOV AND NOVGOROD-SEVERSK

A Gazetteer of Desna, Seym and Lower Sozh Settlements

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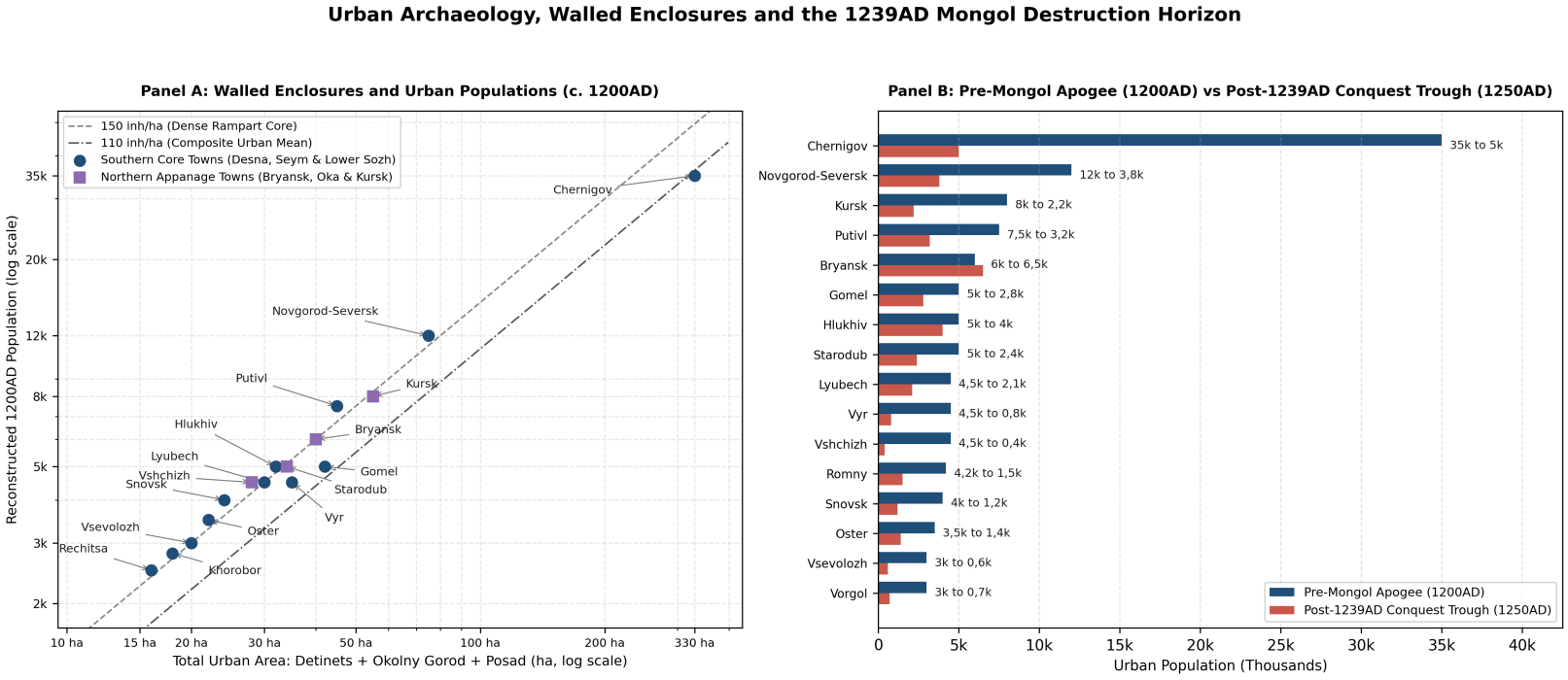


Figure 1. Built-up areas (in hectares) and estimated populations of the principal fortified towns across the 72,24k km² Southern Chernigov-Seversk basin at their pre-Mongol peak in 1200AD — led by Chernigov (330 ha, 35k), Novgorod-Seversk (75 ha, 12k) and Putivl (55 ha, 7,5k) — alongside the urban collapse of 1239AD and the survival of wooded Hlukhiv and Bryansk.

Abstract

This gazetteer compiles population estimates for 142 excavated settlements across the 72,24k km² Southern Core of the Chernigov and Novgorod-Seversk lands (modern Chernihiv and Sumy provinces and the lower Sozh corridor around Gomel) from the Upper Palaeolithic (10000BC) to 1300AD [1][2][3]. Early entries trace the mammoth-hunter winter camps of the middle Desna gorge (Mezin and Pushkari I, 75 - 120 inhabitants in 10000BC), the Early Iron Age promontory forts of the Yukhnovo and Milograd cultures (380 - 780 inhabitants in 500BC) and the tenth-century Varangian-Rus retinue bases at Shestovytsia (3,2k in 1000AD), Lyubech (3,5k) and Boldyni Hory (2,5k).

Under the Olgovichi dynasty in 1200AD, the urban network reached 120 fortified towns (*gorodishcha*), headed by the 330 ha capital at Chernigov (35k), the Seversk seats of Novgorod-Seversk (12k) and Putivl (7,5k), and the river towns of Gomel (6,5k), Snowsk (5k), Kursk (8k in the northern forest-steppe), Hlukhiv (4,5k) and Starodub (4,5k). Following Möngke and Batu's October 1239AD campaign across the Desna and

Seym valleys, 68% of the southern frontier forts were abandoned; Chernigov fell to 4k in 1250AD (recovering to 6k by 1300AD), while princely authority shifted into the wooded refuges of Hlukhiv (4,5k in 1300AD) and Bryansk.

Methodology

Overview of the Settlement Gazetteer

Across the 72,24k km^2 Southern Core of the Chernigov-Seversk lands (Chernihivska Oblast, Sumska Oblast and the Eastern Gomel and Lower Sozh corridor), archaeological surveys and Rus chronicles document 142 major settlements between 10000BC and 1300AD. These range from the Upper Palaeolithic mammoth-bone camps of the middle Desna gorge and the Early Iron Age promontory forts of the Yukhnovo and Milograd cultures to tenth-century Varangian-Rus retinue bases and the fortified *gorodishcha* of the Olgovichi principalities prior to and after the Mongol sack of October 1239. Each entry in the tables below gives the settlement's historical name, geographic coordinates (50,14°N - 53,13°N, 29,83°E - 35,26°E) and estimated population across the benchmark dates.

Population Estimation from Archaeological Evidence

For the Upper Palaeolithic to Early Iron Age (10000BC - 500AD, 22 sites), mammoth-hunter winter camps on the middle Desna (Mezin, Pushkari I, Chulatovo I-II, Novgorod-Seversky and Buzhany) are reckoned at 75 - 120 persons per camp [4][5][6]. Yukhnovo and Milograd Early Iron Age hillforts (0,5 - 3 ha) are estimated at 380 - 780 inhabitants [7], while Late Zarubintsy, Kiev culture (Roishche and Harivka-Desna) and Kolochin (Kolochin I) riverside villages are estimated at 580 - 850 inhabitants [8][9].

For the Volyntsevo, Romny-Severian and Viking-Age centres (700AD - 1000AD), major Severian and Radimichi hillforts (Volyntsevo, Bytytsia, Gornal, Novotroitske and Romny) and Varangian-Rus garrison towns (Shestovytsia at 3,2k, Boldyni Hory at 2,5k, Mokhov at 1,95k and Lyubech at 3,5k) are estimated from excavated house counts (*poluzemlyanki*) and barrow cemeteries [10][11][12].

For the Olgovichi principalities at their twelfth- and early thirteenth-century peak (1050AD - 1239AD), walled *detinets* and *okolny gorod* ramparts (120 - 150 inh/ha) and outer *posad* and *podol* craft suburbs (75 - 100 inh/ha) follow the archaeological surveys of V. P. Kovalenko [1], A. V. Kuza [3][13], P. P. Tolochko [14], A. K. Zaitsev [15], Yu. Yu. Morgunov [2] and H. V. Shtykhov [16]. For the October 1239AD Mongol sack and the post-conquest principalities (1250AD - 1300AD), estimates reflect excavated destruction layers across the Posemye and Desna valleys (Putivl, Vyr, Vorgol, Vsevolozh and Chernigov) and the survival of Hlukhiv (4,5k in 1300AD), Novgorod-Seversk (4,5k), Putivl (3,8k), Gomel (3,4k) and Chernigov (6k) [17][18].

Results

Prehistoric, Proto-Slavic and Viking-Age Sites

Table 1 presents the 22 prehistoric, Early Iron Age, Kiev, Kolochin, Romny-Severian and Viking-Age settlements in the region (10000BC - 1300AD).

Site (Coords)	Cultural Period	10000BC / Early	500BC / 300AD	900AD	1200AD (1300AD)
Mezin (51,83°N, 33,08°E)	Upper Palaeolithic Desna Type-Site	120 (10000BC)	250 (500BC)	400	650 (390)

Pushkari I (52,22°N, 33,29°E)	Pushkari I (Pogon) Mammoth Camp	110 (10000BC)	220 (500BC)	340	520 (310)
Chulatovo (51,95°N, 33,32°E)	Chulatovo I-II Desna Cliff Camp	95 (10000BC)	190 (500BC)	380	580 (350)
Novgorod-Seversky (52,01°N, 33,26°E)	Desna Rock-Shelter Mammoth Camp	85 (10000BC)	320 (500BC)	-	-
Mezhyrich-Desna (51,69°N, 33,15°E)	Buzhany Desna Terrace Camp	75 (10000BC)	260 (500BC)	410	560 (330)
Kurove-Yukhnovo (52,07°N, 33,29°E)	Yukhnovo Iron Age Type-Hillfort	280 (1500BC)	650 (500BC)	520	720 (410)
Sosnytsia-Mnogopillya (51,51°N, 32,5°E)	Sosnytsia Bronze Age Settlement	520 (1500BC)	480 (500BC)	540	690 (400)
Marianivka (51,36°N, 33,52°E)	Marianivka Neolithic/Bronze (Seym)	490 (1500BC)	430 (500BC)	530	680 (380)
Harivka-Desna (51,45°N, 31,25°E)	Harivka-Desna Zarubintsy/Kiev Site	-	790 (300AD)	820	1,1k (560)
Roishche (51,65°N, 31,26°E)	Roishche Kiev/ Chernyakhov Complex	-	850 (300AD)	790	1,18k (640)
Volyntsevo (51,4°N, 33,94°E)	Volyntsevo 8th-9th c. Type-Site	-	420 (300AD)	1,15k	980 (520)
Harivka-Seym (51,34°N, 33,89°E)	Harivka Severian Hoard & Hillfort	-	420 (500AD)	820	890 (460)
Gornal (51,06°N, 35,22°E)	Gornal Romny-Severian Citadel	-	420 (500BC)	1,85k	1,25k (580)
Novotroitske (50,62°N, 34,48°E)	Lyapushkin Excavated Romny Hillfort	-	380 (500AD)	950	640 (340)
Kamyane-Psyol (50,55°N, 34,39°E)	Psyol Romny-Rus Complex	-	340 (500AD)	740	1,12k (540)
Shestovytsia (51,38°N, 31,19°E)	Korovel Viking-Age Retinue (1000AD: 3,2k)	-	420 (500AD)	2,4k	1,85k (780)
Boldyni Hory (51,48°N, 31,27°E)	Boldyni Hory & Chorna Mohyla Suburb	-	750 (700AD)	1,8k	3,4k (1,1k)
Kolochin I (52,27°N, 30,52°E)	Kolochin I 5th-7th c. Type-Site	-	850 (500AD)	750	950 (540)
Milograd (52,24°N, 30,56°E)	Milograd Iron Age Type-Hillfort	320 (1500BC)	780 (500BC)	710	920 (520)
Mokhov (52,02°N, 30,73°E)	Dnieper-Sozh Retinue (1000AD: 1,95k)	-	410 (500AD)	1,45k	1,25k (680)
Vetka-Sozh (52,56°N, 31,18°E)	Sozh Neolithic/ Radimichi (4000BC: 320)	140 (6000BC)	590 (500BC)	750	980 (580)

Avtunichi (51,79°N, 31,42°E)	Excavated Opolye Rural Craft Village	-	320 (700AD)	540	1,1k (520)

Table 1. Estimated inhabitants of the 22 principal excavated prehistoric, Yukhnovo, Milograd, Kiev, Kolochin, Romny-Severian and Viking-Age settlements across the Desna, Seym and Lower Sozh basins, 10000BC - 1300AD. Parenthetical dates in the early columns indicate the benchmark year represented; parenthetical figures in the final column give the 1300AD population.

Principality of Chernigov Core

Table 2 documents the 52 chronicle towns and excavated *gorodishcha* across the Chernigov Core (Chernihivska Oblast) from 800AD to 1300AD.

Settlement (Coords)	800AD	1000AD	1100AD	1200AD	1250AD (1300AD)
Chernigov (51,5°N, 31,29°E)	6,8k	18k	26,84k	35k	5k (6k)
Lyubech (51,7°N, 30,66°E)	2,2k	3,5k	4,02k	4,5k	2,1k (2,5k)
Snovsk (Sedniv) (51,64°N, 31,57°E)	1,95k	2,8k	3,42k	4k	1,2k (1,65k)
Oster (Gorodets) Ostersky (50,95°N, 30,88°E)	1,15k	1,8k	2,68k	3,5k	1,4k (1,85k)
Pryluky (Priluk) (50,59°N, 32,39°E)	1,25k	1,85k	2,55k	3,2k	1,1k (1,55k)
Vsevolozh (Syvolozh) (51,18°N, 32,36°E)	1,15k	1,8k	2,42k	3k	600 (950)
Unenezh (Nizhyn) (51,05°N, 31,89°E)	1,05k	1,6k	2,22k	2,8k	950 (1,45k)
Sosnytsia (51,53°N, 32,5°E)	1,35k	1,9k	2,37k	2,8k	1,15k (1,5k)
Khorobor (Makoshyne) (51,47°N, 32,33°E)	1,08k	1,6k	2,22k	2,8k	900 (1,25k)
Baturin (Baturyn) (51,34°N, 32,88°E)	820	1,2k	1,93k	2,6k	850 (1,2k)
Bakhmach (Bakhmatch) (51,18°N, 32,83°E)	880	1,35k	1,9k	2,4k	750 (1,1k)
Berezna (51,57°N, 31,78°E)	920	1,3k	1,77k	2,2k	900 (1,25k)
Moroviisk (Morivsk) (51,09°N, 30,87°E)	820	1,2k	1,72k	2,2k	800 (1,05k)
Orgoshch (Rohoshchi) (51,63°N, 31,08°E)	860	1,25k	1,69k	2,1k	750 (950)
Varva (Varin) (50,49°N, 32,72°E)	880	1,25k	1,69k	2,1k	720 (980)
Blestovit (Blystova) (51,43°N, 31,93°E)	820	1,2k	1,62k	2k	700 (920)
Mena (51,52°N, 32,22°E)	840	1,15k	1,54k	1,9k	820 (1,15k)
Listven (51,69°N, 31,11°E)	940	1,35k	1,61k	1,85k	620 (780)
Nosivka (Nosov) (50,93°N, 31,58°E)	660	950	1,42k	1,85k	720 (1,05k)
Gurichev (51,41°N, 31,22°E)	790	1,15k	1,49k	1,8k	580 (760)

Lutava (Karpilivka) (50,98°N, 30,82°E)	660	950	1,39k	1,8k	620 (820)
Korop (51,56°N, 32,95°E)	680	950	1,31k	1,65k	780 (1,15k)
Chemer (Chemerin) (51,1°N, 31,22°E)	600	850	1,27k	1,65k	620 (820)
Kovchyn (Pakul)-Bilous (51,46°N, 31,08°E)	740	1,05k	1,36k	1,65k	720 (950)
Borzna (51,25°N, 32,43°E)	580	820	1,15k	1,45k	680 (980)
Horodnya (51,89°N, 31,59°E)	530	750	1,06k	1,35k	680 (950)
Kozelets (50,91°N, 31,12°E)	520	750	1,06k	1,35k	650 (920)
Staryi Bilous (51,49°N, 31,2°E)	530	740	1,02k	1,28k	480 (650)
Bobrovytsia (50,74°N, 31,39°E)	500	720	996	1,25k	580 (840)
Kobyzhcha (50,83°N, 31,28°E)	480	680	950	1,2k	560 (810)
Ichnya (50,86°N, 32,39°E)	470	680	924	1,15k	540 (780)
Vypovziv (50,94°N, 30,8°E)	480	680	924	1,15k	480 (650)
Ripky (51,8°N, 31,09°E)	440	620	870	1,1k	520 (740)
Horbove (51,46°N, 31,59°E)	460	640	879	1,1k	450 (620)
Boiaro (Bruzhytsi) (51,55°N, 31,49°E)	440	620	844	1,05k	420 (580)
Obmachiv (51,37°N, 32,81°E)	410	580	788	980	440 (620)
Olyshivka (51,22°N, 31,33°E)	390	550	774	980	450 (640)
Kyselivka (51,53°N, 31,41°E)	410	580	778	960	390 (540)
Sribne (50,66°N, 32,92°E)	390	550	758	950	430 (610)
Ponornytsia (51,72°N, 32,85°E)	390	550	742	920	420 (590)
Petrushyn (51,63°N, 31,35°E)	380	540	738	920	380 (520)
Novi Mlyny (51,42°N, 32,98°E)	360	520	712	890	410 (560)
Kloniv (Klochkiv) (51,68°N, 31,6°E)	370	520	707	880	370 (510)
Tabayivka (51,62°N, 31,15°E)	360	510	692	860	360 (490)
Berezivka-Udai (50,83°N, 33,14°E)	360	510	692	860	360 (490)
Kulykivka (51,37°N, 31,65°E)	360	520	692	850	390 (540)
Sokyryntsi-Utkivka (50,7°N, 32,79°E)	350	490	672	840	350 (480)
Kruty (51,06°N, 32,11°E)	340	480	657	820	360 (510)
Vykoniv (Desna) (50,93°N, 30,76°E)	320	450	622	780	350 (490)
Radul (51,83°N, 30,72°E)	340	480	620	750	380 (520)
Revna-Snov (52,18°N, 32,58°E)	320	440	596	740	410 (560)

Brech-Snov (51,77°N, 32,25°E)	300	420	576	720	390 (540)

Table 2. Estimated inhabitants of the 52 chronicle towns and excavated fortified settlements (gorodishcha) in the Principality of Chernigov core along the Lower and Middle Desna, Snov and Oster rivers, 800AD - 1300AD. Parenthetical figures in the final column give the post-Mongol recovery estimate for 1300AD.

Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl, Vorgol and Hlukhiv

Table 3 details the 44 princely capitals, chronicle fortresses and excavated *gorodishcha* across the Middle Desna, Seym (Posemye), Esman, Sula, Psyol and Vorskla valleys (800AD - 1300AD).

Settlement (Coords)	800AD	1000AD	1100AD	1200AD	1250AD (1300AD)
Novgorod-Seversk (51,99°N, 33,27°E)	4,2k	7,5k	9,84k	12k	3,8k (4,5k)
Putivl (51,32°N, 33,86°E)	2,7k	4,5k	6,06k	7,5k	3,2k (3,8k)
Hlukhiv (51,68°N, 33,92°E)	1,75k	3k	4,04k	5k	4k (4,5k)
Vyr (Stari Vyrky) (51,16°N, 34,29°E)	1,85k	2,9k	3,73k	4,5k	800 (1,05k)
Romny (Romen) (50,75°N, 33,47°E)	2,4k	3,2k	3,72k	4,2k	1,5k (1,95k)
Vorgol (51,48°N, 33,78°E)	1,15k	1,85k	2,45k	3k	700 (820)
Lipen (Sumy) (50,91°N, 34,8°E)	1,35k	1,95k	2,29k	2,6k	750 (920)
Okhtyrka (Vorskla) (50,31°N, 34,9°E)	1,3k	1,95k	2,24k	2,5k	680 (850)
Voronizh (51,77°N, 33,46°E)	940	1,4k	1,92k	2,4k	920 (1,15k)
Hlinsk (Glinsk) (50,62°N, 33,32°E)	950	1,35k	1,84k	2,3k	950 (1,35k)
Popash (51,02°N, 33,68°E)	920	1,35k	1,79k	2,2k	520 (680)
Konotop (51,24°N, 33,2°E)	840	1,25k	1,69k	2,1k	750 (980)
Viakhan (50,95°N, 33,85°E)	850	1,25k	1,69k	2,1k	480 (620)
Zartyi (51,44°N, 34,05°E)	790	1,15k	1,54k	1,9k	520 (660)
Lipovets (Posemye) (51,2°N, 34,15°E)	740	1,1k	1,49k	1,85k	680 (850)
Nedryhailiv (50,83°N, 33,88°E)	530	750	1,06k	1,35k	480 (620)
Igoreve Seltsye (51,35°N, 33,75°E)	440	650	962	1,25k	420 (540)
Olshana (Lebedyn) (50,58°N, 34,48°E)	510	720	970	1,2k	440 (560)
Zelenyi Hai (50,8°N, 34,85°E)	610	780	988	1,18k	440 (560)
Zarichne (Trostyanets) (50,48°N, 34,96°E)	480	680	924	1,15k	420 (540)
Myropillya (51,02°N, 35,26°E)	510	680	924	1,15k	440 (560)

Vovkivtsi (50,81°N, 33,58°E)	620	820	992	1,15k	460 (590)
Bilopillia-Kryha (51,15°N, 34,31°E)	510	680	909	1,12k	410 (520)
Retezh (Krolevets) (51,55°N, 33,38°E)	470	650	884	1,1k	480 (640)
Pustoviitivka (50,79°N, 33,58°E)	490	640	817	980	410 (520)
Znob-Novhorodske (52,26°N, 33,59°E)	400	550	758	950	460 (610)
Kuzemyn (50,14°N, 34,68°E)	450	590	772	940	380 (480)
Mezhyrich-Psel (50,7°N, 34,47°E)	440	580	767	940	380 (480)
Korovyntsi (50,81°N, 33,74°E)	420	560	747	920	370 (470)
Chasha (Buryn) (51,2°N, 33,83°E)	410	540	722	890	360 (460)
Bytytsia (51,01°N, 34,93°E)	1,65k	620	755	880	340 (430)
Velyki Budky (50,88°N, 33,65°E)	420	540	706	860	350 (450)
Nyzy (50,78°N, 34,77°E)	380	520	692	850	350 (460)
Vorozhba (51,17°N, 34,22°E)	390	520	692	850	340 (440)
Obesta (Shalyhyne) (51,57°N, 34,12°E)	390	520	692	850	480 (580)
Loknya (Yunakivka) (51,11°N, 35,03°E)	380	510	676	830	320 (410)
Syrovatka (Krasnopillia) (50,77°N, 35,26°E)	370	490	656	810	310 (400)
Khorol (Lypova) Dolyna (50,56°N, 33,79°E)	360	480	641	790	310 (400)
Ivot (Shostka) (51,86°N, 33,48°E)	350	480	636	780	390 (490)
Sumka (Stepanivka) (50,94°N, 34,61°E)	350	460	611	750	290 (380)
Yampil-Ivot (51,95°N, 33,79°E)	340	450	601	740	420 (530)
Esman (51,77°N, 34,06°E)	290	420	555	680	480 (580)
Znobka (Seredyna)-Buda (52,18°N, 34,04°E)	310	410	550	680	380 (480)
Banichi (51,51°N, 33,91°E)	270	390	510	620	380 (460)

Table 3. Estimated inhabitants of the 44 princely capitals, steppe-watch fortresses and excavated gorodishcha across Novgorod-Seversk, Putivl, Vorgol and Hlukhiv in the Middle Desna, Posemye and Upper Sula-Psyol valleys, 800AD - 1300AD. Parenthetical figures in the final column give the 1300AD population.

Lower Sozh and Dnieper Corridor

Table 4 documents the 24 chronicle fortresses and Radimichi-Rus *gorodishcha* in the eastern Gomel and Lower Sozh corridor (800AD - 1300AD).

Settlement (Coords)	800AD	1000AD	1100AD	1200AD	1250AD (1300AD)
Gomel (Homiy) (52,43°N, 30,98°E)	2,4k	3,8k	4,42k	5k	2,8k (3,4k)
Bragin (51,78°N, 30,27°E)	1,25k	1,95k	2,5k	3k	1,4k (1,75k)
Rechitsa (52,36°N, 30,39°E)	1,25k	1,8k	2,16k	2,5k	1,5k (1,9k)
Chechersk (52,91°N, 30,91°E)	1,1k	1,65k	1,99k	2,3k	1,3k (1,65k)
Loyev (51,94°N, 30,8°E)	1,08k	1,6k	1,91k	2,2k	1,15k (1,45k)
Khalch (52,57°N, 31,14°E)	860	1,15k	1,31k	1,45k	780 (920)
Streshin (52,73°N, 30,11°E)	540	720	996	1,25k	750 (980)
Gorval (52,57°N, 30,2°E)	540	680	924	1,15k	680 (890)
Zaspa (52,29°N, 30,48°E)	460	620	844	1,05k	560 (720)
Dobrush-Iput (52,41°N, 31,32°E)	430	580	757	920	520 (650)
Pridneprovskoe (Zhlobin) (52,89°N, 30,04°E)	420	560	742	910	520 (650)
Korma-Sozh (53,13°N, 30,8°E)	410	540	706	860	490 (620)
Komarin (51,44°N, 30,56°E)	380	520	692	850	440 (560)
Sharpylovka (52,1°N, 30,91°E)	380	520	692	850	450 (580)
Nisimkovichi (52,88°N, 31,04°E)	390	520	686	840	470 (590)
Svetilovichi-Besed (52,78°N, 31,3°E)	380	510	671	820	460 (580)
Tereshkovichi (52,27°N, 30,95°E)	370	490	646	790	430 (550)
Kholmichi (52,15°N, 30,63°E)	350	480	636	780	420 (540)
Raduga-Sozh (52,64°N, 31,08°E)	340	450	606	750	400 (510)
Neglyubka-Besed (52,66°N, 31,53°E)	350	460	611	750	420 (540)
Strumen (Khoiniki) (51,89°N, 29,96°E)	350	460	606	740	420 (540)
Uvarovichi-Uza (52,6°N, 30,73°E)	340	450	596	730	410 (520)
Vedrich (Vasilevichi) (52,25°N, 29,83°E)	330	440	580	710	400 (510)

Lipov (Buda)-Koshelevo (52,72°N, 30,57°E)	320	430	570	700	390 (500)

Table 4. Estimated inhabitants of the 24 Radimichi-Rus river towns and fortified settlements along the Lower Sozh, Iput, Besed and Dnieper-Braginka corridor in eastern Gomel, 800AD - 1300AD. Parenthetical figures in the final column give the 1300AD population.

Sources

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